preface

When I finally sat down to write about the origins of this book, I realized that my involvement with Behavior-Driven Development goes back much further than I thought.

My first foray into the world of executable specifications was in 2001, though at the time, I didn't know it by that name. In fact, at the time, I didn't know it had a name. I was working on a project to write a pricing algorithm for an insurance company. Along with a hefty 200-page Word document, the client kindly provided us with an Excel spreadsheet containing 6,000 or so rows of sample data that he used to check pricing changes. It was an afterthought: the idea was that we might find the spreadsheet handy to check our pricing application manually. I found it more convenient to set up a test harness to load the Excel data, run it against our pricing algorithm, and check the outcomes. While I was at it, I got the test harness to write an updated version of the spreadsheet—but with extra columns for the calculated values, highlighted in green if they matched, and red if they didn't.

At first nothing passed, and the spreadsheet was solid red. Then, I implemented the application bit by bit, following the large formal specifications document provided by our client, and, gradually, more and more of the spreadsheet went green. We even found a number of errors in the specifications along the way! The resulting code had a near-zero defect rate, and a delighted customer, and my first experiment with what would now be called Acceptance Test Driven Development and Living Documentation was a hit.

I didn't actually hear the term "Behavior-Driven Development" for another six years or so. While I was working on the Java Power Tools book in 2007, my good friend